Praise of the Stūpas of the Eight Great Places

Aṣṭamahāsthānacaityastotra · Toh 1133 · Derge Tengyur
གནས་ཆེན་པོ་བརྒྱད་ཀྱི་མཆོད་རྟེན་ལ་བསྟོད་པ

The Praise of the Stūpas of the Eight Great Places, known in Sanskrit as the Aṣṭamahāsthānacaityastotra and in Tibetan as Né Chenpo Gyé kyi Chörten la Töpa, is a short devotional hymn in verse that its colophon attributes to the great master, the noble Nāgārjuna. Verse by verse it pays homage to the stūpas marking the eight great events of the Buddha's life: his birth at Lumbinī, his awakening beside the Nairañjanā river in Magadha, his first turning of the wheel of Dharma at Vārāṇasī, his great miracles at Śrāvastī, his descent from the realm of the gods at Sāṃkāśya, the reconciliation of the divided Saṅgha at Rājagṛha, the blessing of his life at Vaiśālī, and his passing into nirvāṇa at Kuśinagara. It closes by bowing to the truth body of all the buddhas, which pervades the ten directions like space, and by dedicating the merit of this homage to the awakening of all beings. It is Toh 1133 in the Tengyur, where it belongs to the section of praises (stotra).

In the language of India: aṣṭamahāsthānacaityastotra
In the language of Tibet: Praise of the Stūpas of the Eight Great Places

Homage to Mañjuśrī in youthful form.

The sole guru of beings was born in Lumbinī
And made his home in the city of Kapilavastu:
To the stūpas of the Sugata (the Buddha), adorned with ten million precious qualities,
I pay homage.

In Magadha, at the foot of the tree of awakening,
On the bank of the river called Nairañjanā,
Stands the stūpa of vast qualities:
To this support of awakening I pay homage.

In Vārāṇasī in Kāśī,
The wheel of Dharma, wondrous liberation,
Cuts through the obscurations of the afflictions:
To the four stūpas of wisdom I pay homage.

In Śrāvastī, having crushed the power of his opponents,
He displayed great miracles in the Jeta Grove,

Supremely accomplishing his purpose for the three levels of the world:
To the stūpa where he defeated the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas) I pay homage.

In Sāṃkāśya, the supreme and excellent city,
Having gone to the realm of the gods, he made his unsurpassed descent,
His feet honored by Brahmā and Indra with their crowns:
To the stūpa honored by the Thirty gods I pay homage.

Where, after the Saṅgha had earlier fallen into schism,
The Teacher's hearers (śrāvakas) were wholly reconciled,
In the Bamboo Grove at Rājagṛha:
To the stūpa of loving kindness I pay homage.

Where, after relinquishing the formations of his life,
He again sustained his life by his blessing,
At Vaiśālī of liberation:
To the stūpa of blessing I pay homage.

In Kuśinagara he set beings
To virtue, and in the peerless grove
Of the twin trees in the land of the Mallas:
To the stūpa of nirvāṇa I pay homage.

To these eight stūpas of Śākyamuni,
And to all the truth bodies (dharmakāya) that abide
Elsewhere throughout the ten directions, I bow;
To them, the peaceful, I always bow my head.

Thus, by truly paying homage to the truth body of the buddhas,
Free of all elaboration, incomparable, permanent, and pure in its essential nature, pervading beings like space,
Whatever merit, white as the color of a snow mountain, I have gathered in my mindstream,
By that may all sentient beings without exception realize the bliss of samādhi and attain awakening.

This completes the Praise of the Stūpas of the Eight Great Places, composed by the great master, the noble Nāgārjuna.

Translator's Notes

- For the site at Vārāṇasī the Tibetan reads literally "wisdom stūpa four" (ye shes mchod rten bzhi); it may allude to the Four Noble Truths first taught there. "Stūpa of loving kindness" renders byams ngos, whose second syllable ("side, face") is unclear; the stūpa at Rājagṛha is traditionally the stūpa of reconciliation. "Vaiśālī of liberation" renders rnam grol as written; the stūpa there is traditionally called the stūpa of complete victory (rnam rgyal), which this word may echo.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.